FAMILY PRAYER

Not to Be Neglected

Isaac Backus
(1724-1806)

Family Prayer Not to Be Neglected

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Family Prayer Not to Be Neglected

"That your prayers be not hindered." 1 Peter 3:7

To the Reader

NEW England has been a place famous for religion in general, and for family worship in particular; but lately, the neglect of this and other religious duties has evidently been growing among us. This has caused much grief to godly souls, yet I have not heard that any discourse has been published upon this subject here for many years. Recently, large numbers of people have been remarkably awakened in some parts of the land, who grew up without family prayer, and they are still at a loss about the scripture authority for its daily practice. Therefore, I humbly offer the following considerations to the public, by the advice of friends.

—*Isaac Backus,* pastor of a church in Middleborough, Massachusetts, February 6, 1766

Introduction

The inspired author of this epistle has spoken of the Living Stone that was rejected indeed by men but chosen by God and precious. On this Stone the

saints, as living stones, are built as a spiritual house. He showed that though many stumbled and took offence at this glorious Rock, yet He is precious to believers, who are a peculiar people—that they should show forth the praises of Him Who has called them out of darkness into His marvelous light. He then proceeds to lay down many instructions and exhortations concerning right behavior in the Christian's circumstances and relations. Among the rest, he speaks particularly to husbands and wives concerning how they ought to act towards each other. He gives this as a powerful motive to a right walk together: "That your prayers be not hindered." It is as if he had said, "You are to maintain a constant trade of coming to that Living Stone, and as you are heads of the family, you are to practice worship together daily. But if your duties to one another in the family are neglected, and the adversary can prevail to make division among you, it will have a dreadful tendency to hinder your daily united prayers."

I think it is plain that family prayer is here intended because bad treatment, even from close friends, does not hinder godly souls from privately coming to the throne of grace. Instead, it often makes them more earnest in [private prayer]. In the prophet Micah's time, corruption had advanced so far that no faithful friend was to be seen. This caution was given: "Keep the doors of thy mouth from her that lieth in thy bosom" (Mic 7:5). But when "a man's enemies [were] the men of his own house," then he says, "Therefore I will look unto the LORD;

I will wait for the God of my salvation: my God will hear me" (Mic 7:5-7). Thus you may see that the bad behavior of a wife or family may excite, rather than hinder, secret prayer. David says, "For my love they are my adversaries: but I give myself unto prayer" (Psa 109:4). But for family worship there must be agreement. This makes it clear that family prayer is intended here. I will attempt to say something about family prayer in the following manner:

1. Explain something of the nature of prayer in general;

2. Produce some evidences from Scripture for the daily practice of family prayer in particular;

3. Labor to remove some hindrances that seem to lie in the way of this duty; and then

4. Close with addresses to several kinds of people.

1. Prayer in General

I will endeavor to show something of the nature of prayer in general. I conceive that prayer is the soul's approach to God through a glorious Mediator, by the assistance of the Holy Spirit, to present our supplications, praises, etc., unto Him.

David calls it a pouring out our hearts before Him (Psa 62:8). This may be considered as comprehending the soul's expressing its views of Him, its regards to Him, its desires of help from Him, and its returns of gratitude for favors received.

Here observe, it is *heart exercise*. Many draw near with their mouths while their hearts are far from God. But the prophet says, "With my soul have I desired thee in the night; yea, with my spirit within me will I seek thee early" (Isa 26:9).

And in true prayer, the heart is *poured out*. The inmost griefs, burdens, and desires of the soul are laid open before God. Sins are confessed, needs and miseries are presented, help is requested, arguments are used of various kinds. Petitions and requests are also brought for others at home and abroad, in all places and relations.

There is likewise in a right performance of prayer a *self-dedication and surrender* of our all unto God. "I am thine, save me; for I have sought thy precepts" (Psa 119:94; Isa 64:8-9). Yes, the very nature of prayer implies in it an engagement[1] to receive and use for His glory and in conformity to His will the favors the Lord will grant. Therefore, the sweet psalmist of Israel twice calls the work of praise a paying his vows. In Psalm 116:14-18 and in Psalm 61:4-8, he says, "I will trust in the covert of thy wings…For thou, O God, hast heard my vows…So will I sing praise unto thy name for ever, that I may daily perform my vows." Here, notice that this duty was not to be performed only once a year, once a month, or once a week. It was his daily exercise.

[1] **engagement** – obligation or commitment.

2. Daily Family Prayer in Scripture

This leads me to produce some Scripture evidence for the daily practice of family prayer in particular.

a. Our relation to God as His children

The first shall be taken from our relation to God as His children. He is the Father of all flesh, as He gave them their existence and gives all their enjoyments. He is also the covenant Father in Jesus Christ to all regenerate souls. Now children, especially little ones, as saints are often called, are bound both by duty and inclination to come very often to their parents. It is not their business to provide for themselves, or to be anxious about their future support, but to come to their parents for whatever they need. It is their duty to come daily for instructions about what they should do, and to faithfully observe the same. How loudly this declares the importance of daily prayer! Therefore, as our Savior has informed us that our Father knows what we need, so He has taught us to pray after this manner, "Our Father which art in heaven" (Mat 6:9). These words have been very appropriately explained to be a lesson that teaches us to draw near to God with all holy reverence and confidence, as children to a father who is able and ready to help us, and that we should pray *with* and *for* others.

The fact that He intended that we should come in this manner unto our heavenly Father *every day*

appears very plain from the fourth petition, which is, "Give us *this day* our daily bread" (Mat 6:11). Bread, considered in either a natural or spiritual sense, is what we need every day. Since it is "the living God, who giveth us richly all things to enjoy" (1Ti 6:17), can we do less than ask Him for what we need, and give Him thanks for what we receive? Christ does not say, "Give us this week," or, "this year," but, "Give us *this day* our *daily* bread." And though the Father of our spirits does not need to be informed about our situation, yet He will "be enquired of" by us (Eze 36:37). He will have us acknowledge our dependence on Him and our obligations to Him. And because we have not only personal but also family needs and mercies, and because we are taught to say, "*Our* father…give *us* this day *our* daily bread," I think the evidence appears very clear from this for the daily practice of family worship.

b. The spiritual priesthood of the saints

The spiritual priesthood of the saints will afford further evidence for this duty. Our apostle in 1 Peter 2:5-9 calls them a "holy" and "a royal priesthood." And John calls them "kings and priests unto God" (Rev 1:6). Now the main business of the priests was to minister in God's sanctuary and offer sacrifice upon His altar (Deu 33:10). The high priest was an eminent type of Jesus Christ, Who is now entered, not "into the holy places made with hands, which are the figures of the true; but into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God for us" (Heb

9:24). All the Levitical sacrifices of atonement pointed out that "one offering," by which "he hath perfected for ever them that are sanctified" (Heb 10:14). He alone has answered for all our sins. But their thank offerings and freewill offerings were a figure of the gracious exercises of the saints. It is their "reasonable service" to present their "bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God" (Rom 12:1). And their generous giving is called "an odour of a sweet smell, a sacrifice acceptable, wellpleasing to God" (Phi 4:18; Heb 13:16).

What serves our present purpose even more directly is that their prayers and praises are called this. David understood them in this way in his day: "Let my prayer," says he, "be set forth before thee as incense; and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice" (Psa 141:2). And John speaks repeatedly of "odours" and "incense" which came with "the prayers of the saints" (Rev 5:8; 8:3-4). Those sacrifices were to be presented at God's altar, which sanctified the gift. Hence the sacred writer to the Hebrews, in explaining and applying the spiritual purpose of those ancient ceremonies, says, "We have an altar, whereof they have no right to eat which serve the tabernacle" (Heb 13:10). In other words, those who still held to the shadow when the substance was come, by their unbelief excluded themselves from the benefits of this glorious altar, from whence the prayers of all saints ascend up before God. The inspired penman, having mentioned the place and way of coming, proceeds to our duty in relation to it: "By

him therefore," says he, "let us offer the sacrifice of praise to God continually, that is, the fruit of our lips giving thanks to his name" (v. 15).

Now as he was writing to the Hebrews, there is abundant reason to conclude that here he is referring particularly to their morning and evening sacrifice. When it was first appointed, they were told that it was what they should offer upon the altar "day by day continually," and that it should be "a continual burnt-offering throughout [their] generations" (Exo 29:38, 42). And it is afterwards called a "continual burnt offering" no less than ten times in two chapters. How clear, then, does the evidence appear that the command to offer the sacrifice of praise to God *continually* intends that Christians should be as constant in their offerings of praise as the Jews were in their morning and evening sacrifice!

It might be farther observed that the word *continually* is repeatedly explained by Isaiah to mean the same as "every day" (Isa 51:13; 52:5). It is used in three places in Scripture for people's daily diet. David said to Mephibosheth, "Thou shalt eat bread at my table continually" (2Sa 9:7; see also 2Ki 25:29; Jer 52:33). "Evening, and morning, and at noon, will I pray, and cry aloud: and he shall hear my voice" (Psa 55:17). His addresses to God were as frequent and constant as his regular meals. This was according to God's command in Deuteronomy 8:10: "When thou hast eaten, and art full, then thou shalt bless the LORD thy God for the good land which he hath given thee." The custom of looking to God for a blessing on

their food was so well known in Samuel's time that the young maidens Saul and his servant met could tell them concerning Samuel's going up to the sacrifice (or "feast," as the margin reads it) that "the people will not eat until he come, because he doth bless the sacrifice; and afterwards they eat that be bidden" (1Sa 9:13). This custom is fully confirmed by the example of our Lord and Master, with accounts of His practicing it mentioned in no less than seven places by the evangelists (Mat 14:19; 15:36; 26:26-27; Mar 6:41; 8:6-7; 14:22-23; Luk 9:16; 22:17-19; 24:30; Joh 6:11, 23). The apostle Paul not only imitated this example of his divine master (Act 27:35), but also declares that the meats which seducers would command men to abstain from, God hath created to be received with thanksgiving of them which believe and know the truth. For, "every creature of God is good, and nothing to be refused, if it be received with thanksgiving: For it is sanctified by the word of God and prayer" (1Ti 4:4-5). What can more plainly show that we ought to pray to God than to say that He would sanctify our food to us when we partake of it with thanksgiving to Him for it? Further, the language of the text plainly shows that we have no right to receive the good creature[2] without thanksgiving. The apostle says that God created them for the purpose of being "received with thanksgiving." Nothing is to be refused "if it be received with thanksgiving"; as if to say, They are all God's creatures, and we have no right to any of them without His permission. Well,

[2] **creature** – created thing; here, food provided by God.

they are "sanctified by the word of God and prayer." The Word gives us warrant to receive them by prayer for blessing on them and thanksgiving for them, and in no other way. For if we take them without [prayer and thanksgiving], how is what we do better than robbery? God charged the Jews of old, "Ye have robbed me, even this whole nation" (Mat 3:9); therefore they had a curse even on their blessings because they would "not lay it to heart to give glory" to God's name (Mal 2:2).

This duty was so well known in the earliest period of Christianity that Paul uses it as the basis for an argument. He gives it as a good reason why the weak believer, who still thought some foods to be unclean, should not judge the one who believed they were clean and ate them. Paul says this was because "he that eateth, eateth to the Lord, for he giveth God thanks" (Rom 14:6). Clearly, he did not suppose that a believer would eat of God's good creatures without giving Him thanks. To the same purpose he speaks to the Corinthians, when he asks, "Why am I evil spoken of for that for which I give thanks?" And then adds this command, "Whether therefore ye eat, or drink, or whatsoever ye do, do all to the glory of God" (1Co 10:30-31). Should any say that we may give thanks in our hearts, when it is not openly expressed, I readily grant it. But, where a number of people eat a meal together, out of the abundance of the heart the mouth ought to speak. They must have strange opinions indeed who hold that all these scripture instructions and examples refer only to the

unseen actions of the heart! Thus, I thought it proper to say something concerning the right manner of receiving our food.

c. Ancient example

Our third evidence for family prayer shall be drawn from ancient example. When God called the patriarch Abraham out of his own country into the land of Canaan, his heavenly Friend first appeared to him in the plain of Moreh, and there he built an altar to Him. Then he moved to the east of Bethel and there built another "and called upon the name of the LORD" (Gen 12:8). He did the same at Hebron. And so did Isaac at Beersheba. And so did Jacob both at Shechem and Bethel. Thus, these three eminent fathers, as they moved from place to place, erected altars and called on the name of the Lord in the places where they pitched their tents and where their families dwelt. This speaks forth family prayer strongly indeed. That David did the like seems to be clear from Psalm 141:2, "Let my prayer be set forth before thee as incense; and the lifting up of my hands as the evening sacrifice." So did our Lord with His disciples: "And it came to pass, that, as he was praying in a certain place, when he ceased, one of his disciples said unto him, Lord, teach us to pray" (Luk 11:1). These are some of "the footsteps of the flock," which we are directed to go forth by (Song 1:8).

d. Positive precepts in the New Testament

To this we may add that many positive precepts, which we have in the New Testament, plainly include family prayer, such as the following: "Pray without ceasing. In every thing give thanks: for this is the will of God in Christ Jesus concerning you…Praying always with all prayer and supplication in the spirit, and watching thereunto with all perseverance and supplication for all saints" (1Th 5:17-18; Eph 6:18). None will suppose that to "pray without ceasing" and to "pray always" intends that we should do nothing else but pray. But surely it implies the *daily* practice thereof. And we are here explicitly required to give thanks, not only for some things, or upon some occasions, but "in every thing." This must include family blessings as well as others. Yes, we are commanded to pray "always with all prayer," and who dares to say that *all prayer* does not include family prayer as well as secret and other public prayer? And these duties are to be observed not only for a season, but we are required to watch thereunto "with all perseverance." Other passages might be mentioned to the same purpose; but I shall omit them.

e. A distinguishing mark

Lastly, this exercise is one characteristic by which God's people are distinguished from all others. When the prophet Jeremiah would distinguish the heathen, which knew not God, from His people, he marks them out by this, that they were families

that called not on God's name (Jer 10:25). Here let no one mistakenly think that external observing of this duty is enough. Men may do it and yet be in a miserable state. This is like morality. Though a person may have outward morality without saving grace, yet an immoral man is a wicked man. So [with the duty of family prayer], some whose hearts are not right with God may pray in their families and closets too, but prayerless families are called heathen families.

Thus, I have touched upon some of the evidences from Scripture that we have for this practice. These are so plain that it should seem strange that any who hold to the Scriptures would neglect it. But since many do, I shall proceed to labor to remove some hindrances that seem to lie in the way of this duty.

3. Excuses Answered

a. No command

First, I have known some who would agree that family prayer was a good custom but deny there is any command for it. But if Christ has required us to come with the language of "Our father" to ask that He would "give us this day our daily bread" (Mat 6:9, 11), which so strongly implies that we should come thus every day—and if we are commanded to "offer the sacrifice of praise to God *continually*" (Heb 13:15), which word is so often used for the morning

and evening sacrifice—and if Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob practiced calling on the name of the Lord wherever their families dwelt—if David and also Christ Himself did the like—are we commanded to pray "always with all prayer" (Eph 6:18)—and are husbands and wives required to walk so together that their prayers may not be hindered (1Pe 3:7)—and have we so many precepts and examples for this exercise at mealtimes—and are such called heathen families that call not on God's name (as has been proved above)—what would mortals desire more to prove that God requires them to practice this? Should any (to evade the force of this reasoning) say that these priests, altars, and sacrifices that have been so often mentioned refer to old Jewish ceremonies that have been long out of date? In reply, I would ask a few questions. Were not those ancient ceremonies of God's appointment? And did He not have some wise purpose for them? Were they not shadows of good things to come? Yes, and were they not a part of the Scriptures that "were written for our learning" (Rom 15:4)? Where is the Christian who dares deny these things? Surely then, instead of disregarding them, "we ought to give the more earnest heed" to these things which were first represented by such living pictures, and that have been so clearly explained to us in the New Testament.

b. No inclination

I shall come, secondly, to that which I take to be the greatest hindrance of this duty: the lack of an

inclination for it. Many say prayer should be a heart activity, and when the Israelites' hearts were not right with God, their prayers were looked upon as flatteries and lies (Psa 78:36-37). But is it not strange that those sinners' crimes are now brought to excuse others? They refused to walk in God's law. Instead of taking thankful notice of His dealings, they "forgat his works, and his wonders that he had shewed them" (vv. 10-11). Instead of seeking Him for their food, they rather questioned whether He was able to supply their need or not. They said, "Can God furnish a table in the wilderness?" (v. 19). And when He had given them abundant evidence of His power and goodness, and also some dreadful rebukes for their wickedness, yet, "for all this, they sinned still, and believed not for his wondrous works" (v. 32). They stood it out till death stared them in the face, and then they would pray. "When he slew them, then they sought him" (v. 34). This is the old way that wicked men have trodden. And, O soul, do you choose their path? It seems they would not mock God while they thought they could do without Him. No, then they "turned their back unto [him], and not their face: but in the time of their trouble they will say, Arise, and save us" (Jer 2:27).

One dreadful ingredient in this excuse is making our own inclination our rule, instead of the divine precept. For though the command is to pray "always with all prayer" (Eph 6:18), yet the substance of this objection is, "Because I do not have any inclination to such activities, therefore I am excused from

regarding them." Horrid excuse with a witness! Yet horrid as it is, a great deal of effort has been taken to dress it up and hide its horribleness. Some will plead that saints are called to liberty and that to pray without freedom of mind for it would be to work under a yoke of bondage. This greatly mistakes the nature of the saints' liberty, a great part of which is their open access to the Father through Jesus Christ in all their needs (Eph 2:18; Heb 4:16). David cries out, "O thou that hearest prayer, unto thee shall all flesh come. Iniquities prevail against me: as for our transgressions, thou shalt purge them away" (Psa 65:2-3). Here note well that what many bring as an excuse to keep away, he takes as an errand to come for. As if to say, I find rising corruptions and wrong inclinations to be too strong for me; therefore, I come to You Who are able and ready to pardon and subdue them all.

Our Savior often bids us watch and pray that we enter not into temptation (Mat 26:41). But this excuse would rather teach us to yield to temptation, even when we are drawn away of our own lusts and enticed (Jam 1:14). Little do many see where this would lead them to.

c. Promotes works religion

Others will plead that this insisting upon daily prayer will build people up upon works. To this I reply that though there is a great tendency in mankind to bring in an account of what they have done, like the Pharisee; and to imagine they can demand pay from

God for all their labor like the Jews of old, yet the true nature of prayer is directly contrary to any such thing. Prayer is for a needy creature to come to God for what it needs and thank Him for what it receives. Surely there is a great difference between a guilty or miserable creature that comes to beg for pardon and help, and a merchant that comes with his goods to trade for more. The more destitute the beggar finds himself, the more earnest and incessant are his cries. But the trader, if his goods run out, he draws back till he can get more. And Mary says that the Lord "hath filled the hungry with good things; and the rich he hath sent empty away" (Luk 1:53). Clearly, this very plea springs from a proud, self-righteous disposition. It implies as much as this, that if I feel in a good frame of mind and have something that is good to bring, then I will come, and if not, I will stay away.

David once got into such a frame that he "kept silence," till God's hand was so heavy upon him that he could hold in no longer. Then he confessed his transgressions, and the Lord forgave his sins; and he adds, "For this shall every one that is godly pray unto [him]" (Psa 32:3-6). But lest any should imagine that this was the right way, to hold back until they are thus overpowered, he proceeds to say, "I will instruct thee and teach thee in the way which thou shalt go: I will guide thee with mine eye. Be ye not as the horse, or as the mule, which have no understanding: whose mouth must be held in with bit and bridle" (vv. 8-9). This plainly shows that keeping silence and holding back till we are overcome is acting more like stupid

beasts than like rational souls who have a Father in heaven Who is able and ready to supply all our needs. The regard that He shows to "the prayer of the destitute" and to the cry of the publican may well encourage needy creatures to come to Him (Psa 102:17; Luk 18:13-14).

A right view of our standing before God and of our obligations to Him would silence a thousand such objections. We cannot live, move, nor draw a breath without Him (Act 17:28), whether we acknowledge it or not. All things are naked and opened unto His eyes (Heb 4:13). He sees when we turn to Him "the back, and not the face" (Jer 32:33). He takes notice of such as "will not frame their doings to turn unto" Him (Hos 5:4), who yet in their affliction will seek him early (Hos 5:15), and in their trouble will say, "Arise, and save us" (Her 2:27). How soon would a right view of this make any soul cry out, "God be merciful to me a sinner" (Luk 18:13)! And if He grants pardon, or an inclination and ability to perform any duty aright, as all is received from God, so we owe all to Him and are still deeper involved in the debt of love by all that we thus receive or do. What then have we to boast of or trust in of our own? These things are set in a very moving light in the behavior of that pious king Solomon whom we have often had recourse to before. When he had made vast preparations for the temple of God out of his own goods, and had moved the elders of Israel to do the like, so that they had collected as much gold and silver as is computed at about thirty million

sterling, besides other materials—yes, and had done it joyfully and willingly too—yet, you may see how far he was from thinking that God was indebted to him for all this by considering his language before a great assembly of people:

"Thine," says he, "O LORD, is the greatness, and the power, and the glory, and the victory, and the majesty: for all that is in the heaven and in the earth is thine; thine is the kingdom, O LORD, and thou art exalted as head above all. Both riches and honour come of thee, and thou reignest over all; and in thine hand is power and might; and in thine hand it is to make great, and to give strength unto all. Now, therefore, our God, we thank thee, and praise thy glorious name. But who am I, and what is my people, that we should be able to offer so willingly after this sort? for all things come of thee, and of thine own have we given thee. For we are strangers before thee, and sojourners…all this store that we have prepared…cometh of thine hand, and is all thine own" (1Ch 29:11-16).

Here it might be worthwhile to compare this with the language of the proud king of Babylon and the proud Pharisee of Jerusalem. The first of these says, "Is not this great Babylon, that I have built for the house of the kingdom by the might of my power, and for the honour of my majesty?" (Dan 4:30). And the other prayer is, "God I thank thee, that I am not as other men are…I fast twice in the week, I give tithes of all that I possess" (Luk 18:11-12). Mark well the difference [between these prayers and Solomon's

prayer]. One uses the ambitious pronouns *I* and *my* three times, in a way that ascribes all temporal things to *self,* without the mention of God's name in the affair. The other, after just mentioning the divine name once, uses the great *I* four times with relation to his religious exercises. However, Solomon outdoes them both on the other hand, yes, more than double. He makes use of the terms *thine, thou, thee,* and *thy* no less than sixteen times in this passage, in a sense that ascribes all his enjoyments and performances to God, both earthly and spiritual. Yes, he speaks with thankful surprise that they should be able to offer so willingly and be allowed to handle so many of their Master's goods and lay them at His feet. He says, "Of thine own have we given thee" (1Ch 29:14). This is an example worthy of our close attention. It is ignorance of God and keeping at a distance from Him that promotes self-righteous conceits. These all vanish when we come near to Him. When Job had wandered from his God, he was greatly ensnared with a self-justifying disposition. When he was brought near to Him, he says, "I abhor myself, and repent in dust and ashes" (Job 42:6).

4. Exhortations

Other hindrances I will have the opportunity to mention in addressing several kinds of people, to which I now proceed.

a. Heads of families who neglect daily family worship

Dear Sirs, will you allow this unworthy instrument to ask you a few serious questions?

1. Is this neglect because *you see no warrant for this duty?* If so, then please review the case again, and in the fear of God search His Word and consider well if there is not as plain evidence for it, both by precept and example, as there is for almost any point of Christian practice. And consider also whether it is not our reasonable service that we should seek the Lord, and that daily, since it is in Him we live, move, and have our being (Act 17:28). Consider whether those who neglect it do not act more absurdly than irrational animals. For we are told that "the young lions roar after their prey, and seek their meat from God" (Psa 104:21), and that "he giveth to the beast his food, and to the young ravens which cry" (Psa 147:9).

2. Is your neglect due to *a lack of inclination?* Surely the thought of this might well alarm your soul! "For the wrath of God is revealed from heaven against all ungodliness and unrighteousness of men, who hold the truth in unrighteousness" (Rom 1:18). It is a great truth that "God is a Spirit" (Joh 4:24) and is to be worshiped spiritually; yet this truth is held in unrighteousness while it is held as an excuse to withdraw from our daily acknowledgements of His favors. "For," says the apostle, "the invisible things of him from the creation of the world are clearly seen, being understood by the things that are

made, even his eternal power and Godhead; so that they are without excuse: Because that when they knew God, they glorified him not as God, *neither were thankful*" (Rom 1:20-21). And the following part of the chapter shows that for this cause they were given up to the most amazing blindness and awful abominations that mortals ever knew.

3. Do you appeal to *the bad behavior of any that practice family prayer* as an excuse for your neglect, as I have known some to do? I think you will be ashamed, in the open light of day, to stand in this for even a minute. Who ever acted more abominably in prayer than the Pharisees? Yet how far was that from hindering the abundant practice of it by Christ and His followers?

4. Is this neglect caused by *things being out of order in your family*? Oh, then do not rest until those disorders are corrected! A family that [is so disorderly] as to prevent the worship of God in it must be a dreadful place. One may justly say of it, as Jacob did of Simeon and Levi, "O my soul, come not thou into their secret: unto [such a family], mine honour, be not thou united" (Gen 49:6). Joshua's resolution for himself and his family deserves our warmest regard: "As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD" (Jos 24:15). Nor is David's example less worthy of notice. When he set up his home, instead of letting in vanity and iniquity as many do, he invited God home with him, saying, "O when wilt thou come unto me? I will walk within my house

with a perfect heart: I will set no wicked thing before mine eyes" (Psa 101:2-3).

But do you say, I have no gracious[3] people in my house to join with me? That is truly a sad condition to be in. However, as our warrant for social worship[4] does not depend on our certainly knowing that we have gracious souls present with us, and as all are God's creatures, who are under many obligations to acknowledge Him, we may boldly come to the throne of grace, where "the general assembly…of the firstborn, which are written in heaven" all meet, and may there present our praises and requests (Heb 4:16; 12:22-24).

5. Do any excuse themselves because of *the smallness of their abilities*? I would only ask such whether that prevented them from coming in their childhood to their earthly parents for what they needed? If not, then why should it hinder us from coming to Him Who knows what we have need of before we ask Him? (Mat 6:8).

Before I take my leave of you who profess religion and yet neglect the daily practice of social worship, I would earnestly desire you to view the inconsistency that there is between your profession and practice. It is generally recognized that a leading point in the profession of Christianity is the

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[3] **gracious** – characterized by the grace of God at work in them; regenerated by God's Spirit.

[4] **social worship** – worship by a group, in contrast to individual worship in private.

ordinance of baptism, notwithstanding men's different judgments about the time and manner of administering it. And those who hold to infant baptism often bring this as a great argument for it: that their children will be heathens if they are not baptized. Others can hardly look upon any to be Christians that have not been baptized by immersion. Now, reader, if you are of either of these sentiments, what consistency can there be between your profession and your conduct? If of the former, then how can you prove that your family are Christians when they have the very badge of heathenism that the prophet distinguishes them by? [That is, prayerlessness.] And if you are of the latter sentiment, how can your character be any better secured, while so important an article of Christian behavior is neglected. [That is, prayer.] Baptism is a putting on Christ (Gal 3:27) and contains an engagement to "walk in newness of life" (Rom 6:4). But if we think that the one act [of baptism] without living such a life will be sufficient, we shall find ourselves greatly mistaken. No doubt but you will find that many outward difficulties and inward struggles will rise against prayer, as well as against other duties; but if you neglect them because of [the difficulties], I leave you to answer to Him Who has said, "Whosoever doth not bear his cross, and come after me, cannot be my disciple" (Luk 14:27).

b. To those who practice family worship

My address to you will be by way of advice and exhortation.

1. *Rest not in the mere external performances of this duty*. James tells us that, while many receive not because they ask not, others ask and receive not because they ask amiss, that they may consume it upon their lusts (Jam 4:2-3). He says, "God resisteth the proud, but giveth grace unto the humble" (Jam 4:6). And among other things which he advances on this subject, he brings in the example of Elias, who though a man of like passions with us, yet "he prayed earnestly," and he repeatedly obtained his request. "He prayed earnestly," or as it is in the margin, "He prayed in his prayer" (Jam 5:17-18). So, my friends, if we pray in our prayers, we shall find it not to be in vain.

2. *Take good heed to your walk*. Obedient children will come to their parents, not only for food, but for instruction about what they should do, and will be as much concerned to obey their commands as to obtain their help. So says our apostle, "As obedient children, not fashioning yourselves according to the former lusts in your ignorance: But as he which hath called you is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation" (1Pe 1:14-15). Many are ready to [claim] as an excuse any evil behavior that they can discover in those who profess [family prayer] as well as other duties of religion. Peter tells us, "It is the will of God, that with well doing ye may put to silence the ignorance of foolish men" (1Pe 2:15).

3. *Content not yourself with family prayer alone*. We are to pray *always* with *all* prayer and watch thereunto with *all* perseverance (Eph 6:18).

4. *Beware of turning back from these ways*. If any man draw back, Christ's soul will have no pleasure in him (Heb 10:38). This is set in a very striking light in the 81st Psalm, where God reminds His people of the wonders which He had done for them and says, "Thou calledst in trouble, and I delivered thee…Hear, O my people, and I will testify unto thee…There shall no strange god be in thee…I am the LORD thy God…open thy mouth wide, and I will fill it" (Psa 81:7-10). As if He had said, Thou hast found Me to be a God hearing prayer, and I am always the same; therefore regard no others, but open thy mouth wide, enlarge thy desires to Me as much as you will, and I will fill them. But instead of continuing their regard to Him, He goes on to say, "My people would not hearken to my voice; and Israel would none of me. So I gave them up unto their own hearts' lust: and they walked in their own counsels" (Psa 81:11-12). What a terrible condition! To be given up to your heart's lusts is one of the greatest judgments on this side of hell. How we need then to cry daily, "Lead us not into temptation, but deliver us from evil" (Mat 6:13)!

c. To young people

What I have at present to say to young people is: Learn the importance of setting out with God and travelling through the world with God. This was the

way that the first man took who got to heaven without seeing death (Enoch, Gen 5:22-24). And this is the command of our divine Lord: "Seek ye first the kingdom of God, and his righteousness; and all these things shall be added unto you" (Mat 6:33).

To the same purpose is the language of David to you: "Come," says he, "ye children, hearken unto me: I will teach you the fear of the LORD. What man is he that desireth life, and loveth many days, that he may see good?...Depart from evil," etc. (Psa 34:11-14). Take heed, dear youth! You are called upon from two very different quarters. Satan promises you the kingdoms and glories of this world, if you will take his ways of deceit, vanity, and iniquity. On the other hand, here are these calls from heaven to choose the way of truth and holiness, and the promise thereupon of all blessings, both in this life and that which is to come. Which will you believe? Which will you regard? As surely as God speaks the truth, the way to enjoy good days here is to walk in the way of truth, peace, and holiness. Every soul which yields to the contrary enticements practically declares that God is a liar, and that the devil is to be believed instead of Him!

Be astonished, O heavens, at this! What conduct can be more absurd than for a creature, who wants to enjoy the good things of the Creator, to take a course opposed to Him to obtain them? It is particularly absurd for one who needs an agreeable companion and to get comfortably settled in the world, to give himself up to vanity and iniquity [at such a

time], even more than at other times. Solomon says, "A prudent wife is from the LORD" (Pro 19:14). How then can any expect to obtain a prudent wife in a way of disregard to the Lord? Those who take such a course do what they can, as it were, to force the Divine Being to hedge up their way with thorns and strip them of their enjoyments, in order to bring them to a right sense of things (Hos 2:6-15). Or else He may let them have the "waters of a full cup" and an "increase in riches" for a little space, until they slip into destruction in a moment and are "consumed with terrors" (Psa 73:10, 12, 18-19). You would pity a slave or criminal who was forced to labor all day to collect a bed of thorns to lie down in at night; or to gather a large quantity of fuel for his own burning. Yet this is what the sinner chooses for himself. While he hardens his heart against God and abuses his goodness, he is spending his life in treasuring up "wrath against the day of wrath" (Rom 2:4-5). Oh, how different from this is the case of an old grey-headed saint who can appeal to God that He has been his trust from his youth, and that he has gone in His strength, and trusted in His righteousness only (Psa 71:5, 16, 18). He can say, when the time of his departure is at hand, "I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course…Henceforth there is laid up for me a crown of righteousness, which the Lord, the righteous judge, shall give me at that day" (2Ti 4:6-8). This is a happiness worth striving for indeed!

Every soul is pursuing after happiness, though most of the children of men take the way that leads

directly away from it. Therefore, take a brief description of a truly happy man in the following lines, with which I shall conclude:

The happy man is born of God,
A penitent indeed:
His soul is washed in Jesus' blood
And follows him with speed.

His mind is taught by truth divine.
His will is ruled thereby;
And his affections therewith join
In sweetest harmony.

Christ's yoke upon his neck he wears.
He yields his all to God.
This empty world, with all its cares
Under his feet are trod.

His Father's precepts he obeys,
Still with a ready mind;
And unto all His sovereign ways
Lies cheerfully resigned.

His morning and his evening cries
Come up before the throne,
Perfumed with Jesus' sacrifice,
In Whom he trusts alone.

The great concern upon his mind
Is how to honor God;
And for to benefit mankind,
Upon this earthly clod.

This is the end for which he lives;
All other things look vain.
This is the prize for which he strives,
While life or breath remain.

Humility his soul doth clothe.
Contentment fills his mind;
And he within his heart doth loath
All sin of every kind.

His thoughts do often mount the sky
And view the world above:
He sees the glorious bridegroom nigh,
Which fires his heart with love.

God is his portion and his guide
Through this dark wilderness;
And when this flesh is laid aside,
His soul has endless rest.

And when the judge shall from his throne
Pass sentence upon all,
He'll rise to dwell with the Holy One,
Free from all sin and thrall.[5]

O Lord of hosts, unto my soul
Much of this pleasure grant!
This is the all; this is the whole;
What else then can I want!



[5] **thrall** – slavery.